



IN A WAR ZONE
A television
journalist reports
on the Mumbai
terror attacks
from the Gateway
of India

transport came to a halt and the police started asking people to put up their hands and come out of their cars. Nobody was above suspicion. It was sheer providence that we found Mohammad Rahman, a taxi driver outside the Taj Lands End, who agreed to ferry us to the Taj and the Trident. When I asked him his name, he responded almost apologetically, "Islam does not advocate murdering innocents." The drive from Bandra was fast as Rahman zipped through empty streets. The phone kept us updated on the shootouts as reports of firing outside Vidhan Bhavan came in, where Ajmal Amir Kasab and Abu Ismail had hijacked a Skoda.

We reached the Trident post midnight. Outside the hotel, I saw many of my beliefs coming apart. Despite all the problems, there's a method to our madness, I felt, but on that fateful night, on seeing the police force naked in its helplessness, I realised that this country

runs not because of the system but in spite of it. Camping outside the Trident was a rather out-of-control Mumbai Police Commissioner Hasan Gafoor in his Honda City, consulting businessmen and army officers alike on how best to deploy the army and navy personnel. He seemed to be marking his presence at the spot rather than coordinate with his force. Gafoor refused to brief the commanders of different agencies and did not even speak to the hostages to find out the number of terrorists inside the hotel, fearing it would be construed as a sign of weakness. The Opposition saw an opportunity in the crisis as it indulged in sloganeering. It was quite disheartening to see senior officers not speaking with each other.

It was 3 a.m. when we reached the Taj. Army and navy teams had already surrounded it. It was agony to see terrorised guests and employees rush out of there drenched in blood, as guns continued to reverberate and the heritage wing was set on fire. With the Mumbai Police and other specialised units in a state of disarray, the rescued guests had nobody from the Government or police to calm frayed nerves or help them.

When Everyone Lost Something

By Amitabh Srivastava

It was the most blood-chilling scream I had ever heard. Rising above the sepulchral silence of the relief camp, it almost ruptured my eardrums. Flanked by photographer Ranjan Rahi, I had just entered the Saharsa Zila School—where more than a thousand Kosi flood victims had taken shelter. I saw a 39-year-old man spreading his arms wide and run madly across the school playground till a volunteer caught him by the waist and hauled him back. He then crawled, clawing the earth, uprooting grass, all the while making that unnatural sound. "*Hey Bhagwan... aisa kyon kiya... nahi aisa mat karna.*" This man had lost his entire family in the flood. He was the solitary survivor and he knew it. Being from Bihar, I know what floods mean and before leaving for the flood-affected areas, I had gritted my teeth anew at what I thought was a journalist's cast-iron heart.

But what I saw was worse than what we can imagine and endure. I saw thousands of homeless residents wading through knee-, and often, waist-deep water and walking for miles to reach "some destination". With meagre belongings on their heads and babies in their arms, they were running away from swirling waters. I saw people crammed cheek-by-jowl under the shade of a temple, a railway wall-clock and some